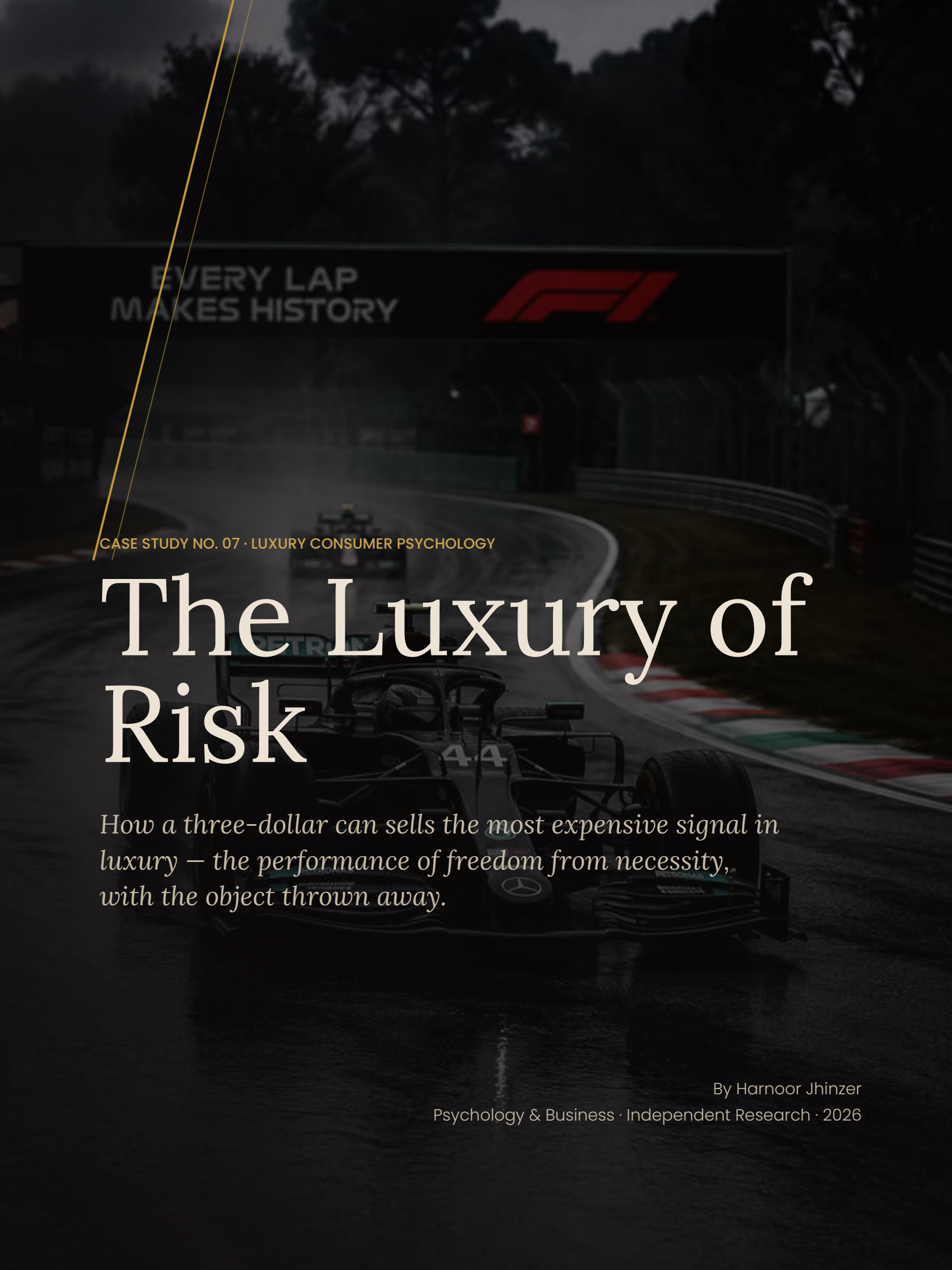
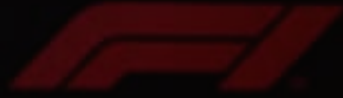




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CASE STUDY NO. 07 · LUXURY CONSUMER PSYCHOLOGY

The Luxury of Risk

How a three-dollar can sells the most expensive signal in luxury — the performance of freedom from necessity, with the object thrown away.

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SECTION I

The Provocation

Red Bull is a luxury brand.

I am aware of how that sounds. Luxury is supposed to be scarce, and Red Bull sells nearly fourteen billion cans a year. Luxury is supposed to be expensive, and Red Bull costs about three dollars. Luxury is supposed to be hard to reach, and Red Bull is in every gas station, every vending machine, every checkout cooler on earth. By every conventional measure of the category — rarity, price, exclusivity of access — Red Bull is the opposite of luxury. It is one of the most widely available consumer products ever made.

So the claim looks indefensible. Hold onto it anyway, because the discomfort is the point. The claim only collapses if you assume luxury is *only* the thing — the rare leather, the precious stone, the four-figure price. The object is real, and its value is real: craft, material, scarcity, heritage all genuinely matter, and most of this archive is about exactly that. But the object was never doing the work *alone*. Luxury runs on two things at once — the object, and the signal it carries: proof that whoever holds it is free of necessity. Two levers, almost always pulled together.

Red Bull is interesting because it pulls only the second one. It has no precious material, no craft worth the name, no object anyone would call beautiful — and it sells the freedom-from-necessity signal anyway, at scale, for three dollars. So I'm not going to argue that Red Bull belongs on a shelf next to Hermès — it doesn't, and the people who guard that shelf are right to keep it off; the object that earns that shelf is precisely what Red Bull lacks. I'm going to argue something more specific: that Red Bull isolates the *one lever* of luxury that has nothing to do with the object — the performance of freedom — and runs it harder, and more nakedly, than almost any house alive. By the end, the opening line will mean something narrower and stranger than it did when you bristled at it. That's the trick. Stay with me.

SECTION II

Status Was Always a Show

What money buys, and what it performs

Begin with the lever this essay is about. One of the things luxury sells — alongside the object itself — is the visible evidence of freedom from necessity: proof that survival and income are not the things organizing your day. The watch is partly the watch — the movement, the metal, the make. But it is also a signal: that its owner was free enough to want it. The luxury this essay tracks is that second part — being free enough to spend three months on a mountain because there is no clock you have to punch.

This is the oldest idea in the study of status, and it was named more than a century ago. In 1899 the economist Thorstein Veblen published *The Theory of the Leisure Class* and gave the mechanism its name: conspicuous consumption, conspicuous waste, conspicuous leisure.¹ The operative word in all three is the same, and it is the one people forget. *Conspicuous*. It has to be seen. Veblen's leisure class did not hoard its advantage quietly; it performed it — through visible idleness, visible waste, pursuits that paid nothing back and were prized precisely because they paid nothing back. His phrasing is almost shockingly direct: conspicuous abstention from labor becomes the mark of reputability, while *application to productive labor becomes a mark of poverty and subjection*.¹ To work is to broadcast that you must. To be seen not working is to broadcast that you needn't.

So this lever of luxury — the status part — was never quiet. It was always theater. The mansion exists to be looked at; the party exists for the people who weren't invited; the waste is the message. This is the world of a hundred years ago — Veblen in 1899, the Gilded Age in full swing — and the machinery has not changed. Even the modern cult of "quiet luxury" is spectacle; it is simply spectacle performing the *absence* of spectacle, restraint pitched at an audience refined enough to read it. The whisper is as staged as the shout. As a *signal*, status is a show or it is not status.

None of this denies the object. The craft, the weight of a thing in the hand, the material, the heritage — these carry real value, and they are not reducible to signaling; much of what I write about elsewhere is exactly that value. But the object does two jobs at once. It is a real thing, and it is also a marker of the freedom its acquisition implies — the surplus, the distance from necessity, that having it advertises. The two usually travel together. Veblen named the second job, and would surely have found it absurd to point his framework at a canned drink. But his insight — that status is the *performance* of exemption from necessity — is the sharpest lens we have for the brand we're about to look at, because that brand kept the performance and threw the object away.

And if this lever works by *performing* freedom from necessity, then the question becomes: what is the most vivid possible way to stage that performance? Not idleness. Idleness is the

quiet version. The loudest version is risk.

SECTION III

Conspicuous Risk

The body as the thing you can afford to waste

Here I want to extend Veblen, because there is a category he reached toward but never named for the modern world.

Veblen knew the leisure class had older and harder roots than mere idleness. He traced its status back to what he called predatory exploit — the prowess of the hunt, the raid, the duel.¹ Before the nobleman performed status by *not* working, he performed it through the one kind of exertion that was honorable precisely because it was dangerous and produced nothing: hunting for sport, riding to hounds, going to war for glory rather than wages. He proved his rank by courting danger that served no economic purpose. The serf could not afford to court it. The serf was needed in the field, alive.

Bring that forward. In a developed society raw survival is mostly solved; almost no one hunts to eat. So the predatory-exploit signal mutates into something I'll call conspicuous risk: the recreational courting of physical danger as a display of status. The logic is Veblen's, merely updated. To risk your body for fun is to prove your survival is so secured, so far from precarious, that you can afford to gamble the one thing nobody gets back. Only a person whose tomorrow is guaranteed can treat their body as a toy.

I should be honest about the limits of the parallel, because an attentive reader will press here and they'd be right to. Veblen wrote before the modern risk economy, and today's extreme sport is not the raw aristocratic gamble it imitates — it is produced, insured, safety-engineered, ringed with medical teams and edited for maximum effect. Much of what reads as danger is, for the professional, a managed performance of danger. And the class story is messier than a clean line: some genuinely precarious people take the largest real risks, for money, while the secured take smaller ones for an audience. The signal is not as pure as Veblen's hunt. And status today is fragmented in a way Veblen never had to reckon with — quiet wealth, moral signaling, tech-founder asceticism, sheer viral fame, all of them competing status games that often outrank physical daring. Conspicuous risk is one lane among several, not the throne. But the underlying logic still travels intact: in a world where survival is largely

solved, the recreational courting of physical danger remains an unusually *legible* way to display surplus safety — and Veblen could not have anticipated the multiplier that makes Red Bull's version so potent, which is that the display is now filmable, algorithm-fed content, a risk performed for a camera and distributed to millions rather than witnessed by a hunting party of a dozen. The wingsuit still says *I have so much security I can spend it on the chance of dying for no reason* — only now it says it to the entire internet at once. That is conspicuous leisure raised to its most vivid power, and then amplified: the thing being conspicuously wasted is not money or time, but safety itself.

Hold that concept — conspicuous risk, the performed display of expendable safety — because it is the engine of everything that follows, and the specific show that one three-dollar product has built an empire on staging.

SECTION IV

What Red Bull Is Actually Selling

A media company with a drink attached

Start with the fact that surprises people: Red Bull is barely a beverage company. It is closer to a media and content company that happens to attach a drink. By widely cited estimates it pours something on the order of a quarter to a third of its revenue — figures in the billions — not into conventional advertising but into producing content, owning events, and funding athletes; the exact number is impossible to pin down, because the company is private and discloses little.² Analysts describe the model as an inversion of the usual order: rather than making ads to sell a product, Red Bull built a media operation and bolted a product onto it.² The can is not the point. The can is the souvenir stand at the entrance to the actual product, which is a *world*.

And look at what that world is made of. Red Bull sponsors or employs hundreds of athletes across dozens of countries; it owns two Formula 1 teams and a portfolio of football clubs.³ Most tellingly, it does not merely sponsor extreme sport — it *manufactures* it, inventing spectacles that did not exist before the brand willed them into being: cliff diving, air racing, a human-flight contest, downhill ice racing. Its defining act was Red Bull Stratos in 2012, a production reported to cost tens of millions of dollars, in which a man fell to earth from the edge of space — watched live by millions, with a total reach that climbed toward a billion in the days after.³

Notice the single thread through all of it. Every Red Bull spectacle asks the same question: *how far can a human body be pushed before it breaks?* The freefall from the stratosphere, the cliff dive, the wingsuit threading a canyon — the subject is always the body at its limit, and the thrill is always its proximity to ruin. Red Bull is not in the energy business. It is in the conspicuous-risk business. It has assembled the best-funded catalogue of expendable-safety imagery on earth and made it the core product, deliberately.

The architecture reinforces this at every level. The pricing is a signal, not an accident: by costing meaningfully more than the cheap alternatives, Red Bull leans on the instinct that the dearer version must be the potent one, and the small can — a concentrated dose, not a bulk refreshment — reads as something precise and faintly pharmaceutical rather than something you guzzle.² And the company has never gone public; it is held privately between two families, which lets it behave like a heritage maison rather than a quarterly-earnings machine — spending a decade and a fortune building a *world* with no pressure to convert it into a same-quarter sale.⁴ That patience is exactly the posture of a luxury house. Red Bull simply aimed it at danger instead of leather goods. (The same privacy, it's worth noting, also spares the company hard questions about selling a potent stimulant to the young — but more on the cost of all this shortly.)

So the engine is complete. Red Bull stages the spectacle of conspicuous risk — freedom from necessity in its most vivid, body-on-the-line form — and uses the can as the gateway. Which raises the obvious problem, and it is the one the whole essay has to survive.

SECTION V

Nobody Is Buying the Soda

An ecosystem, entered at different depths

The thing to understand about Red Bull's consumer is that there isn't *one*. There's an ecosystem, and the can is only its lowest rung. What Red Bull built is not a customer base; it is a world with tiers of entry, and people buy in at whatever depth they can afford.

Start near the top, with the proof that the soda was never the point. Open the apps and you'll find a whole genre of it: grown adults filming themselves doing stunts, captioned some version of *Red Bull, let's work*. These are not broke kids begging for a handout. The person with a hundred thousand followers, a camera crew, a filming budget, and the free time to plan and

execute a stunt is, self-evidently, not poor — staging that footage costs real money and real surplus. He isn't auditioning from outside the gate. He's a near-peer, a small node of the same spectacle, proposing to merge his version with the big one: *yo Red Bull, let's collab*. And that is exactly the tell. He is performing his *own* freedom from necessity — look at the crew, the gear, the fact that I can afford to risk my body for content — in precisely the way Red Bull performs its. Conspicuous risk doesn't stop at the brand; it runs all the way up the ecosystem. You don't propose a collaboration to a world you're outside of. You propose it to the world you're already standing in.

Beneath the creators are the watchers — the tens of millions consuming the content, and among them the people buying the can. *This* is the cheapest rung: three dollars to hold a piece of the world the creators above you are wealthy enough to actually live in. Red Bull's drink-buyers skew young, concentrated in their late teens and twenties, male, students and gamers and young workers.³ But the mistake is to call them "the consumer" and stop there, as if they were a separate class from the people performing the stunts. They're the same ecosystem at a different altitude. The creator buys in with a production; the kid buys in with a can; the difference is means, not motive. Everyone is purchasing proximity to the same signal — *free enough to gamble the body* — at the price they can pay. The brand is the product. The drink is just the entry-level ticket.

I should be honest that not every can is bought for the feeling. A large share of Red Bull's volume is purely functional: the long-haul driver, the gamer four hours into a session, the night-shift worker, the student cramming, the person who simply likes the taste and wants to stay awake. None of them is enrolling in a risk identity; they want caffeine. But this doesn't escape the argument — it is the argument, because the no-name can on the next shelf has the same caffeine for a fraction of the price, and they reach past it for the bull anyway. The brand world is what lets Red Bull charge the premium over a chemically identical drink, which means even the buyer who wants nothing but a stimulant is quietly paying the conspicuous-risk markup. The feeling is priced into the can whether you came for it or not. And it is worth saying plainly what the can is: a potent stimulant, sold hard to the young, with documented links to disrupted sleep and cardiac strain — especially in the mixed-with-alcohol, multiple-cans-a-day patterns the brand's own world quietly normalizes.

The psychology underneath the buy-in is real and not flattering. A consistent body of research finds energy-drink consumers score higher than non-consumers on impulsivity, sensation-seeking, and risk-taking;⁵ the sociologist Kathleen Miller built a construct around the pattern in young male consumers — a "toxic jock" identity binding hyper-masculinity to risk-taking and energy-drink use.⁶ Sensation-seeking, as the psychologist Marvin Zuckerman

originally defined it, is precisely the willingness to take physical and social risks for the sake of intense experience.⁷ The people drawn to this world tend, on average, to be built for it.

But there's a hole in that research worth naming, and it makes the picture darker, not cleaner. Correlation is not direction. A can holds roughly an espresso's worth of caffeine, and caffeine is a stimulant that can, in the moment, lower inhibition and tilt behavior toward impulsivity — so some of the link may run the other way: the drink producing the recklessness, not the reckless choosing the drink. Miller herself declined to draw a clean arrow, pointing to a common factor feeding both.⁶ The honest answer is that it isn't an arrow at all. It's a loop. A disposition toward risk draws a person in; the drink, chemically, nudges them further toward it; and the entire surrounding world — the athletes, the stunts, the wings — tells them, relentlessly, that risk is *who they are*. Temperament, chemical, and identity all push the same way, and the company sits in the dead center of the circuit, taking a cut of every turn.

This is what should harden how you see it. Red Bull doesn't merely *find* the sensation-seeker or merely *create* one; it closes the loop between disposition, stimulant, and identity, and sells the result back as a feeling about yourself. And while the funded creator performs the safe, sponsored, insured version of risk with a medical team on standby, the watcher buys the feeling of that world in a cheap, unsupervised form — the all-nighter, the energy-and-vodka that strains a heart not built for it, the fast drive home — and pays for it in the only currency that rung can spend: money, sleep, and sometimes health. The wingsuit belongs to the man who can afford the crew. The can belongs to the man watching him. Red Bull sells the first man's freedom to the second man as a feeling, and collects from both.

That is the trick, and it is the indictment in the same breath.

SECTION VI

The Collab — Loud Money, Quiet Money

A thought experiment in collision

So let's have some fun with it. What if Red Bull and Chanel did a collaboration?

On its face it's absurd — and the absurdity is the entire point. Think about Barbenheimer: a candy-colored doll comedy and a three-hour film about the atomic bomb, released the same day, with nothing in common but a date.⁸ No shared audience, no shared tone, no shared

anything. It became the movie event of the year precisely *because* the two films were extreme opposites, and the collision — not any rational link between them — was the product.⁸ The internet did the rest: the memes, the double-feature tickets, the arguments about which to watch first.⁹ Nobody needed the two films to *rhyme*. They needed them to *clash*.

That's the model. A Chanel × Red Bull collaboration doesn't need a thesis to justify it. It needs a contrast violent enough to become an event — and there is no sharper contrast in branding than the quietest house on earth and the loudest.

Now the honest part, because the constraints are what make it interesting. Chanel would almost certainly never do this. It is the most collaboration-averse house in luxury — it opts out of the collab circuit its rivals run on,¹⁰ guards its codes so fiercely it has sued people for repurposing its scarves into shirts,¹¹ and built its entire power on control, scarcity, and distance from exactly the kind of mass, loud spectacle Red Bull is made of. As a real deal it is close to unthinkable. But that is precisely why Chanel is the right name and not Louis Vuitton. Louis Vuitton collaborates with everyone — a Louis Vuitton × Red Bull would be a Tuesday. Chanel × Red Bull is impossible, and impossible is what makes it a moment.

So if it can't be a product — and it can't; a co-branded can or a winged handbag is a punchline, and Chanel would never let its codes be slapped onto a stimulant — then it has to be a single, staged, cultural moment. One image. And the image isn't "beauty plus danger," which is just two words sitting next to each other. The constraints give you something exact. Chanel's brand-essence is *composure* — total, serene, untouchable control. Red Bull's brand-essence is the body at the edge of death. Fuse those two specific things and the frame writes itself: composure inside danger. Not beauty beside risk, but Chanel's perfect stillness placed at Red Bull's moment of maximum peril — a figure in complete couture composure exactly where there should be only chaos and falling. The Chanel-ness is the calm; the Red Bull-ness is the danger. One frame renders both brands' actual souls and lets the contrast detonate.

And you'd stage it the way both houses actually work. Chanel builds worlds for a single night — it has turned a Paris exhibition hall into a supermarket, a rocket, an iceberg.¹² Red Bull builds the impossible live and films it — it put a man in freefall from the edge of space and streamed it to millions.³ So the collaboration is two spectacle-machines combining their stages. You don't manufacture the moment — Barbenheimer could not be manufactured; the audience made it, and forced collisions are rejected as fake.⁹ You build the conditions, give people one image that has genuinely never existed, and let them turn it into culture.

The point was never to prove the two brands are alike. They aren't. The point is the click of recognition when the loudest party and the quietest party turn out to be thrown for the same reason — to be *seen* being free. You can find a thread anywhere if you know what you're looking for. This one doesn't need a thread. The contrast is enough.

SECTION VII

Closing

The cheapest expensive thing in the world

So: is Red Bull a luxury brand? Not in the way you heard it on the first line. It fails every object-test of the category — it's cheap, it's everywhere, it's poured by the billion, and any argument that tries to smuggle it onto the shelf beside Hermès deserves to be knocked down in a sentence.

But that was never the claim. The claim is narrower and stranger: that *one* of luxury's levers — the performance of freedom from necessity, the most expensive and least transferable thing a person can display — can be pulled all by itself, with no object attached. The shelf still matters; the craft and the material are still real, and most of this archive is about them. Red Bull is the proof of what happens when you keep only the signal and throw the object away. It isolated that single lever — *I am free enough to gamble my body for fun* — and staged it for the masses at three dollars a can.

And here is the part that should stay with you. At the top of the ecosystem are people with the crew, the budget, and the surplus to perform risk and call it a collaboration. At the bottom is the person buying the can — paying three dollars for the feeling of a world the people above him are wealthy enough to actually live in. And the same drink that *fuels* his grind — the cram session, the double shift, the long drive — is the one selling him the fantasy of a life with no grind in it at all. It is the energy to keep striving, sold as the feeling of never having to.

That is the most expensive thing Red Bull sells, and it is the cheapest thing in the store. It is the mass distribution of a freedom its buyers are paying, three dollars at a time, to feel as though they have. And learning exactly how that is built — how a show becomes a product, and a product becomes a way of belonging — is what I intend to spend a career doing.

NOTES & SOURCES

- 1 · Veblen, T. (1899). *The Theory of the Leisure Class*. Macmillan. Conspicuous consumption / waste / leisure; predatory exploit as the older root of leisure-class status. "Conspicuous risk" is presented as an extension of Veblen, not an independent coinage.
 - 2 · Red Bull's "media-house" model and pricing-as-signal — brand-strategy analysis; Interbrand / Brand Finance (2023–2026). Marketing reinvestment (~25–30% of revenue) is an **estimate**; the company is privately held and discloses no breakdown.
 - 3 · Scale: ~13.97 billion cans (2025); 750+ athletes across 70+ countries; two Formula 1 teams and a portfolio of football clubs; invented events (Flugtag, Crashed Ice, Air Race, Cliff Diving). Red Bull Stratos (2012): production ~tens of millions; ~8 million concurrent live viewers, total reach climbing toward a billion afterward. Core drinkers skew 18–24, male.
 - 4 · Ownership: Yoovidhya family (~51%) / Mateschitz family (~49%); never publicly listed — the basis for the "patient capital / heritage-house" posture.
 - 5 · Arria et al. (2010–2011); Miller & Quigley (2011) — energy-drink consumption correlated with higher impulsivity, sensation-seeking, and risk behaviour (correlational; paired with a causation hedge).
 - 6 · Miller, K. E. (2008). Wired: Energy drinks, jock identity, masculine norms, and risk taking. *Journal of American College Health*, 56(5), 481–489. The "toxic jock" construct; Miller's refusal to draw a one-way causal arrow (a common factor feeding both).
 - 7 · Zuckerman, M. (1979). *Sensation Seeking: Beyond the Optimal Level of Arousal*. Erlbaum.
 - 8 · Barbenheimer — two tonally extreme films released the same day; the contrast itself became the event.
 - 9 · Barbenheimer was audience-made; such collisions cannot be manufactured top-down without being rejected as inauthentic.
 - 10 · Chanel's collaboration aversion — it opts out of the constant-collaboration model run by Louis Vuitton, Gucci, and Fendi; the reason Chanel, not LV, is the right name.
 - 11 · Chanel's aggressive protection of its codes, including litigation over unauthorised repurposing and resale.
 - 12 · Chanel's immersive show sets — the Grand Palais staged as a supermarket, a rocket launch, an iceberg — evidence of existing world-building spectacle muscle.
- Health note: energy drinks carry documented links to disrupted sleep and cardiac strain, particularly with alcohol co-consumption and multi-can daily patterns. Stated as documented links, not as causal claims about any individual.